



YOU ARE **38 WEEKS AND 5 DAYS**
9 days to go...

YOUR BABY TODAY

It can be hard to accurately predict the size of a newborn baby. An ultrasound can estimate the weight, but as with all other measurements at this time, it has a fairly wide margin of error.

“Don’t just wait for contractions—it’s worth familiarizing yourself now with the signs that may mean labor is imminent.”

If it’s your first pregnancy, it can be difficult to recognize the signs that the baby is on their way. Some women get lower back pain that is minor before becoming painful. You might notice a [bloody show](#), which can happen well before true labor actually starts. Your water may break as the sac containing the amniotic fluid bursts open. Even if your water breaking is not accompanied by contractions, you should still inform your doctor of what is happening.

Finally, the most obvious sign is contractions: these painful tightenings of your uterus will increase in intensity and become more regular as labor progresses. Contractions are associated with the dilation and shortening of your cervix, so your doctor will examine you to see how far you’ve progressed (see [Changes to the cervix and Dilation](#)).

If you think that you are in labor, stay calm and call your doctor or prenatal provider. Inform them of your symptoms and, especially, describe your contractions and whether your baby is moving. If you’re having contractions every 5 minutes that last for a minute (time them), and they’re so uncomfortable that you’re forced to stop what you’re doing, you should think about going to the hospital.

FETAL MONITORING

If there are no complications or reasons for concern, your baby’s heartbeat will usually be monitored using a handheld device much like the one used during your prenatal appointments. You may be hooked up throughout the entire labor and birth, or your nurse may listen to your baby’s heartbeat every 15 to 30 minutes, which means that you can move around as much as you like in between these checks.

If you’ve had complications in pregnancy, or problems develop during labor, the doctor may monitor the heartbeat using a [CTG](#) and transfer you to a labor ward.

ASK A DOCTOR

How long am I likely to stay in hospital after the birth? After a vaginal delivery, you will usually stay 1–2 days after in the hospital. If you had a Cesarean delivery, you will typically stay 2–3 days